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The Shunammite woman

A generous woman who made room for God's prophet and would not let go when her son died.

The Shunammite woman of Shunem was wealthy enough for Scripture to call her "a great woman." She began inviting the passing prophet Elisha to meals, then she and her husband built him a small room of his own. She asked for nothing, yet God gave her a son. Years later the boy died in her lap. She set out at once for the prophet, told all who asked, "It is well," and would not leave Elisha until he came. Her son lived again. Her story shows quiet generosity and fierce faith.

At a glance

Name	Not given. She is known by her town, Shunem
Described as	"A great woman," meaning wealthy or prominent (2 Kings 4:8)
Family	An older husband; one son, born as Elisha promised
Home	Shunem, in the tribe of Issachar (Joshua 19:17–18)
When	Elisha's ministry, probably under Joram, c. 852–841 BC
Key people	Elisha, Gehazi, her husband, her son, the king of Israel
New Testament	Not named

"Run now, I pray thee, to meet her, and say unto her, Is it well with thee? is it well with thy husband? is it well with the child? And she answered, It is well."

2 Kings 4:26, KJV

The life of The Shunammite woman

Scripture gives no dates. Her story falls within Elisha's ministry (c. 850–795 BC), probably during the reign of Joram (c. 852–841 BC). The famine lasts seven years.

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| Elisha's travels | ● Welcomes the prophet
Whenever Elisha passes through Shunem, she urges him to stop and eat at her home. She tells her husband she believes he is a holy man of God. <i>2 Kings 4:8–9</i> |
| Soon after | ● Builds him a room
She suggests they make a little room on the wall, with a bed, a table, a stool and a candlestick. Elisha can rest there whenever he comes. <i>2 Kings 4:10–11</i> |
| One visit | ● A son is promised
Elisha wants to repay her. She asks for nothing, but Gehazi notes that she has no son and her husband is old. Elisha promises a son, and the next year she gives birth. <i>2 Kings 4:12–17</i> |
| Years later | ● Her son dies
Out in the field with the reapers, the boy cries, "My head, my head." He dies on his mother's knees at noon. She lays him on the prophet's bed and rides to Mount Carmel. <i>2 Kings 4:18–25</i> |
| The same day | ● Her son is raised
She refuses to leave Elisha, so he comes himself. He prays and stretches himself on the child, who sneezes seven times and opens his eyes. <i>2 Kings 4:26–37</i> |
| Seven years | ● Famine and exile
Elisha warns her that God has called for a seven-year famine. She takes her household to live in the land of the Philistines. <i>2 Kings 8:1–2</i> |
| On her return | ● Land restored
She comes to the king to plead for her house and land just as Gehazi is telling him her story. The king restores everything, plus the harvest income of the years away. <i>2 Kings 8:3–6</i> |

Key activities

Scripture tells us little about her husband. When she hurries off, he only asks why she is going to the prophet on an ordinary day (2 Kings 4:22-23). She carries the grief and the hope largely alone.

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- 1 **Showed persistent hospitality.** She "constrained him to eat bread," and afterward he stopped there whenever he passed by. *2 Kings 4:8*
 - 2 **Planned practical care.** She thought ahead about what a travelling prophet would need and provided it. *2 Kings 4:10*
 - 3 **Was content.** Offered a favour from the king or the army captain, she answered, "I dwell among mine own people." *2 Kings 4:13*
 - 4 **Guarded her heart.** When told she would have a son, she begged Elisha, "do not lie unto thine handmaid." *2 Kings 4:16*
 - 5 **Spoke faith in grief.** To her husband she said, "It shall be well," and to Gehazi, "It is well." *2 Kings 4:23-26*
 - 6 **Refused to let go.** She caught Elisha by the feet and said, "As the LORD liveth, and as thy soul liveth, I will not leave thee." *2 Kings 4:27-30*
 - 7 **Obedied a warning.** She left her home and land when Elisha told her a famine was coming. *2 Kings 8:1-2*
 - 8 **Asked for justice.** She went to the king herself to claim her house and land. *2 Kings 8:3-6*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names her.

Old Testament

2 Kings 4:8–37	and 2 Kings 8:1–6. These are the only accounts of her life.
Echoes	Sarah is promised a son "according to the time of life" (Genesis 18:10–14), the same phrase Elisha uses (2 Kings 4:16). Elijah raises the son of the widow of Zarephath (1 Kings 17:17–24).

New Testament

Hebrews 11:35	"Women received their dead raised to life again." Many readers see her, and the widow of Zarephath, in these words.
Echoes	Jesus raises a widow's son at Nain, a village close to Shunem (Luke 7:11–17). "He that receiveth a prophet in the name of a prophet shall receive a prophet's reward" (Matthew 10:41). "Be not forgetful to entertain strangers" (Hebrews 13:2).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did she say to her husband, to Gehazi and to Elisha after her son died (2 Kings 4:22–28)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think she kept saying "It is well" when her son lay dead at home?
3. *Apply:* She made a room with a bed, a table, a stool and a lamp. What practical hospitality could you offer someone this month?
4. *Apply:* She would not let Elisha go (2 Kings 4:30). What need should you keep bringing to God instead of giving up?